

Can I use this image?

The single most expensive mistake a small publisher makes is reusing a photograph from someone else's article. Credit does not make it legal — a credit line is a courtesy, not a licence. This page is the two-minute check before any image goes in.

The rule that matters most: "publicly available" and "public domain" are not the same thing. Almost everything on the open web is publicly available and still fully copyrighted. Public domain is a specific legal status — normally a government work, or something old enough that copyright has expired.

LOOK AT THE CREDIT LINE UNDER THE PHOTO FIRST

Stop — do not reuse

- Reuters, AP, AFP, Getty, EPA, Bloomberg, Shutterstock
- Any wire service or picture agency at all
- Another newspaper's own staff photographer
- No credit line shown anywhere
- "All rights reserved" in the footer

These agencies scan the web for unlicensed use and invoice for it. Demands typically run from several hundred to a few thousand dollars per image, and being a small publisher is not a defence.

Usually fine — but record it

- A Creative Commons mark: CC0, CC BY, CC BY-SA
- UN Photo, UN agencies, UNDP, UNEP
- Government works (NASA, NOAA, most .gov)
- An NGO's own press or media kit
- Unsplash, Pexels, Wikimedia Commons

Still check the specific licence — see the table below. And still fill in the credit and source fields; that record is what protects you later.

CREATIVE COMMONS, DECODED

LICENCE	USE IT?	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS FOR US
CC0	Yes	Given away entirely. No credit required, though we give it anyway.
CC BY	Yes	Free to use commercially. You must name the creator — which our credit field does.
CC BY-SA	Yes	Same, and fine for a website. Credit is required.
CC BY-NC	No	NC = non-commercial. Once the site carries advertising we are commercial. Off limits.
CC BY-ND	Rarely	ND = no derivatives. Blocks cropping, and every template crops. Avoid.
Editorial use only	No	Common on paid stock. Cannot appear on a page carrying advertising.

WHEN YOU ARE CURATING AND WANT THE SOURCE ARTICLE'S PHOTO

- 1

Read the credit under the image. If it names an agency, stop — use one of the routes below instead.
- 2

Email the organisation the story is about and ask for a photo. NGOs, projects and universities nearly always say yes, are pleased to be asked, and send you something better than the original. Save their reply.
- 3

Or use your own separately-licensed image from Unsplash, Pexels or UN Photo, and link out to the source article for the reporting.
- 4

Whatever you choose, fill in the credit, source URL and licence fields. The site will not let you publish without them.

WHAT THE SITE RECORDS FOR EVERY SINGLE IMAGE

FIELD	WHY IT EXISTS
Credit line	Prints under the photo automatically. "Photograph: Name / Source, licence".
Source URL	The page you actually got it from, so the claim can be re-checked years later.
Licence	Chosen from a fixed list, not typed. If a licence is not on the list, the image is not usable.
Permission note	For images sent to you directly — paste who granted it and when.

If you are ever unsure about a specific image, the safe move is to pick a different one. There are millions of free images and only one reputation. This sheet is guidance based on the published licences, not legal advice.